



DELHI | The Own Goal Game

The Congress is falling off the Bhopal tightrope, leader by leader. It seems as if every Congressman has a view, that too a different one, on the Bhopal gas tragedy. From Cabinet ministers Pranab Mukherjee and Veerappa Moily to the dial-a-contradiction General Secretary Digvijay Singh as well as R.K. Dhawan, Prabha Thakur and Satyavrat Chaturvedi. The only ones silent are Sonia and Rahul Gandhi, other than Arjun Singh, the man who was chief minister-in-apathy during the tragedy. A cacophonous Greek chorus reflects the Congress confusion. It first has to defend the then government headed by prime minister Rajiv Gandhi for letting Union Carbide boss Warren Anderson leave the country. At the same time it cannot be seen as indifferent to the victims. Hence Veerappa Moily's attempt to shift the blame to the judiciary, by saying the charges had been reduced to a "car accident". Others then made it a blame game between Congress governments at the time in the state and at the Centre. Mukherjee's spin sounded best, quoting Arjun's 1984 statement: "Anderson was let off to avoid law and order problems." An exasperated Congress General Secretary Janardhan Dwivedi issued a terse warning: "Those holding responsible party posts should speak to the media only on subjects which are their responsibility." Little wonder then that they call the Congress a party of self-goals. **by Priya Sahgal**

**ARJUN SINGH
(ABOVE); THE
UNION CARBIDE
PLANT IN
BHOPAL**

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days is the deadline given by the prime minister to the Bhopal Group of Ministers to work out a roadmap for compensation to the victims.